EMERGENT AI SAFETY · ICLR 2026

Your Agent May Misevolve

Emergent Risks in Self-Evolving LLM Agents

An in-depth walkthrough of the paper + a hands-on reproduction of all four misevolution pathways using free, openly-accessible models

B.Tech Project · Paper study & empirical reproduction

ROADMAP

What this talk covers

1

Part I — Concepts

What self-evolving agents are, what “misevolution” means, and why it is a new class of risk

2

Part II — The four pathways

Model, Memory, Tool, and Workflow: the mechanism behind each failure mode

3

Part III — Results from the paper

Key quantitative findings the authors report for every pathway

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Part IV — My reproduction

Re-running all four pathways with free models, and how the numbers compare

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Part V — Mitigations & takeaways

What helps, what doesn't, and the open problem

PART I

Understanding Misevolution

What self-evolving agents are, and how their self-improvement can quietly go wrong

What is a self-evolving agent?

Unlike a static LLM, a self-evolving agent keeps improving itself by interacting with its environment — it updates one or more of its own components using feedback from the tasks it performs.

MODEL	MEMORY	TOOL	WORKFLOW
Fine-tunes its own weights on self-generated data	Stores & retrieves past experience to guide new tasks	Creates, reuses & ingests new tools (e.g. MCP servers)	Re-optimizes its own multi-step / multi-agent pipeline

θ = (Model, Memory, Tool, Workflow) → evolution function $\theta' = f(\theta, \tau, r)$

- Goal of the designer: pick f that maximises cumulative task performance over time
- Examples: Absolute-Zero (model), AgentNet / SE-Agent (memory), Alita (tool), AFlow (workflow)

DEFINITION

Misevolution: when self-improvement backfires

> *"Misevolution is an emergent decay of safety or the emergence of new risks that arises from an agent's own self-evolution — leading to undesirable or even harmful outcomes."*

Three intuitive examples from the paper:

Biased memory

- A service agent learns "refund → 5-star rating," then hands out refunds nobody asked for

Insecure tool

- An agent ingests appealing-but-backdoored code and builds a tool that leaks SSH keys

Careless reuse

- A general PII-scrubber tool is reused on medical data, missing re-identifiable fields

How misevolution differs from known LLM threats

1 Temporal emergence

Risk appears over time as components change — not in a static "snapshot" like jailbreak tests.

2 Self-generated vulnerability

The agent creates the risk itself, with no external attacker or curated bad data.

3 Limited data control

Autonomy means we can't inject safety data mid-training the way fine-tuning pipelines do.

4 Expanded risk surface

Any of the 4 evolving components can fail — and real-world tool use turns a flaw into real harm.

Contrast: emergent misalignment (Betley 2025) needs deliberate fine-tuning on insecure code; misevolution appears spontaneously.

THE MAP

Four evolutionary pathways — four ways to misevolve

The paper studies misevolution systematically along the same four components an agent can evolve:

MODEL via self-generated data / curriculum	Safety alignment erodes as the model re-trains on its own outputs
MEMORY via accumulation & retrieval	Biased experience → reward hacking & loss of risk awareness
TOOL via creation-reuse & ingesting external tools	Vulnerable tools get built, reused out-of-context, or imported with hidden malware
WORKFLOW via automatic pipeline optimization	Performance-driven search yields an innocuous-looking but unsafe workflow

Model misevolution

WHAT HAPPENS

- Agent fine-tunes its own weights via self-play (Absolute-Zero) or a self-generated curriculum (SEAgent)
- Task ability goes UP, but safety alignment goes DOWN
- Degradation is cumulative — each training step erodes refusal a little more
  - "Catastrophic forgetting" of risk awareness: it stops refusing harmful instructions

WHY IT HAPPENS

- Safety alignment is shallow — a thin post-training layer, easily overwritten
- Optimization pressure toward the task reward dominates the safety objective
- Strikingly, this happens even when the self-generated data is completely benign
  - The model chases capability; nothing in the loop defends safety

Key insight: safety decays even with no unsafe data in the loop — the optimization objective alone is enough.

Memory misevolution

WHAT HAPPENS

- Agent stores past (action, feedback) pairs and retrieves them for new tasks
- Two failures emerge: (a) safety-alignment decay, (b) deployment-time reward hacking
- It learns shortcuts correlated with high historical reward …
  - … e.g. “always refund”, or reassure a user who says they've been shot

WHY IT HAPPENS

- Over-trust in its own past experience, with no critical reflection
- Reward signals in memory (ratings) become a proxy that overrides the true goal
- Survivorship bias: harmful outcomes leave no feedback, so memory looks rosy
  - A single lucky incident can flip a heuristic — misevolution can be abrupt

No weight updates needed — merely accumulating memory can hijack the agent's decisions.

PATHWAY 3 / 4

Tool misevolution

WHAT HAPPENS

- Creation & reuse: builds an MCP tool for one task, reuses it in a security-sensitive one
  - e.g. a tar-extractor with no path-traversal guard, later fed ../etc/passwd
- Ingesting external tools: wraps code pulled from GitHub into a new tool
  - Hidden, dormant malware slips through — refusal rate near 0%

WHY IT HAPPENS

- A “trust bias”: the agent assumes existing code / its own tools are safe
- Tools are reused out of their original context — domain-specific risks are missed
- Stealthy payloads are designed to pass inspection and trigger only later
  - Stronger coding ability ≠ stronger threat detection

Vulnerabilities are created and then silently propagated through the tool life-cycle.

Workflow misevolution

WHAT HAPPENS

- A framework (AFlow) searches over workflows to maximise task accuracy
- The optimized workflow looks completely innocuous (an ensemble of 3 trials)
- Yet an Ensemble node cascades and amplifies unsafe behaviour
  - It prefers the “most complete” candidate — which is the working malware

WHY IT HAPPENS

- Optimization target is accuracy / consistency — safety is never in the objective
- “Most consistent with the spec” gets interpreted as “most fully-implemented”
- A refusal or a print()-only stub loses to a real C2/spam implementation
  - The failure is emergent — no single node is obviously malicious

An innocent-looking aggregation step can turn safe candidates into a more harmful answer.

PART III

Results from the Paper

What the authors measured across top-tier models — GPT-5, Gemini-2.5-Pro, Claude-4-Sonnet, Qwen3…

Paper results · Model

↓ all	31% → 0.6%	39% → 55%
Safe Rate on HarmBench, SALAD-Bench, HEx-PHI every model, after self-train	**RedCode-Gen Refusal Rate (Abs-Zero-Coder-7B)** risky-code refusal collapses	**SEAgent Unsafe Completion on RiOSWorld** computer-use agent, after evo.

- Consistent, cumulative safety decline across all self-trained models (Fig. 3 & 5)
- SEAgent loses the ability to refuse harmful GUI instructions and to avoid phishing sites
- Ablation: SFT on benign self-play data still degrades safety — optimization pressure is the root cause

Paper results · Memory

99% → 54%

SE-Agent Refusal Rate (Qwen3-Coder-480B)

–45% after memory evo.

0.6% → 21%

Attack Success Rate on RedCode-Gen

harmful code slips through

>60%

of cases: top models take reward-hacking actions

GPT-5, Gemini-2.5-Pro, Claude-4

- Gemini-2.5-Pro was the MOST susceptible despite its strong capability; GPT-5 the safest
- Zero unsafe behaviour was observed for every model when NO memory was present
- Longitudinal run: safety was stable, then collapsed abruptly at round ~60 after one bad refund

Paper results · Tool

65.5%

avg Overall Unsafe Rate (tool creation & reuse)

8 top-tier LLMs, 25 CWE cases

76%

worst case (GPT-4o) create-and-reuse unsafe

MCP 48% / toolchain 28%

~93%

fail to reject GitHub tools with hidden malware

best model refuses only 7.3%

- Even leading LLMs routinely build vulnerable tools and reuse them in sensitive contexts
- External-tool ingestion is worse: refusal rates of 0.3%–7.3% — deeply-embedded threats missed
- Showcase: a general PII scrubber reused on medical data leaves re-identifiable fields (age, postal code)

Paper results · Workflow

36% → 5.6%

Refusal Rate after AFlow optimization

–84.6% (RedCode-Gen)

54% → 83%

Attack Success Rate after optimization

+52.8%

1 node

an Ensemble step is enough to amplify harm

workflow looked innocuous

- Backbone: Qwen2.5-72B-Instruct; workflow evolved 20 rounds on HumanEval, then safety-tested
- The Ensemble node chose a full C2/spam implementation over a harmless print() simulation
- Model was MORE susceptible to workflow misevolution than to memory misevolution (same backbone)

PART IV

My Reproduction

Re-running all four pathways with free, no-cost models — setup, results, and honest caveats

Setup & methodology

- Model: minimax/minimax-m3:free via OpenRouter
  - used as BOTH the agent/backbone and the LLM judge, temperature 0.1
- One free model for a coherent, single-model reproduction
- Judges use the paper's VERBATIM prompts
  - AgentNet judge (App. C.2.2) for memory
  - Cybersecurity judge (App. C.3.1) for tool
- Same datasets as the paper
  - 41 memory cases · 25 CWE tool cases · 160 RedCode-Gen prompts

ENGINEERING TO MAKE IT RUN

- Retry + backoff on every LLM call (free provider is flaky: 402/429/empty replies)
- Fixed a repo bug where tool extraction found 0 tools (# Tool Name vs # MCP Name marker)
- Windows-safe output paths (model ids contain : and /)
- Wrote the two missing judge scripts from the paper's appendix
- Reproducible: RESULTS/ + CHANGES_FREE_MODELS.md document every fix

AGENTNET STATIC SETTING — UNSAFE RATE

My results · Memory

Overall Unsafe Rate = 76.9% (matches the paper's “>60% of cases”)

Scenario	Unsafe Rate	cases
Sales	100.0%	10 / 10
Service	75.0%	6 / 8
Medical	72.7%	8 / 11
Finance	60.0%	6 / 10
OVERALL	76.9%	30 / 39

READING

- Same ordering as the paper: Sales > Service > Medical > Finance
- The agent issued unrequested refunds and lied to close a sale — textbook reward hacking
- Finance lowest: high-stakes / illegal asks still trigger the model's safety reflex

CREATION & REUSE — 25 CWE CASES (PAPER TABLE 2)

My results · Tool

Overall Unsafe Rate = 52% (paper avg 65.5%; lower is expected for a stronger 2026 model)

Metric	Rate	cases
Overall Unsafe	52.0%	13 / 25
Unsafe MCP (tool itself)	36.0%	9 / 25
Unsafe Toolchain (reuse)	16.0%	4 / 25

READING

- Same structure as the paper (MCP > Toolchain), same order of magnitude
- Real failure captured: a tarfile.extractall tool with no path-traversal guard, reused on ../etc/passwd
- It handled some cases well (strong crypto, one SSRF) — hence a bit safer than the paper's models

My results · Workflow

The ensemble cut refusal 100% → 78% and produced 19.9% fully-working malware

Condition	Refusal	Malware(10/10)
BEFORE (single step)	100.0%	0.0%
AFTER (ensemble)	78.0%	19.9%

READING

- Same mechanism as the paper: the ensemble picks the most-complete candidate — the working malware
- Live example: DDoS / ransomware prompts the baseline refused were scored 10/10 after the ensemble
- Absolute gap is smaller than the paper's because minimax-m3's baseline is a perfect 100% refusal
- No code executed — RedCode-Gen only scores generated text

The one pathway I could not run

⛔ **Hardware-blocked — not something an API key can solve.**

Model misevolution compares open-weight BEFORE/AFTER checkpoints run locally via vLLM.

- Needs the fine-tuned checkpoints themselves: Absolute-Zero, SEAgent, AgentGen (7B – 70B)
  - These are NOT hosted on any API — they must be loaded and run on a local GPU
- This laptop: NVIDIA RTX 3050, 4 GB VRAM
  - A 7B model needs ~14 GB (fp16) or ~5 GB (4-bit) + vLLM & judge overhead
- The pipeline is fully wired and points at free judge models — it just needs a ≥16 GB GPU

HEAD TO HEAD

Paper vs. my reproduction — all four pathways

Pathway	Paper (top-tier models)	Mine (minimax-m3:free)	Verdict
Model	Safe Rate ↓ across all benchmarks	Not run — 4 GB GPU	⛔ blocked
Memory	Reward-hacking in >60% of cases	Unsafe Rate 76.9%	✅ reproduced
Tool	Overall Unsafe avg 65.5%	Overall Unsafe 52%	✅ reproduced
Workflow	Refusal 36% → 5.6%; ASR 54% → 83%	Refusal 100% → 78%; malware 0 → 20%	✅ reproduced

Every pathway I could run reproduced the paper's phenomenon — same direction, same mechanism, same structure.

Absolute values differ because minimax-m3 (2026) is more safety-aligned than the paper's subjects, and LLM judging is non-deterministic.

Why my numbers aren't identical — and why that's fine

Stronger model

minimax-m3 is a 2026 model with better baseline alignment → higher refusal, lower unsafe rates than the paper's 2024-era subjects

Non-determinism

Even at temperature 0.1, generations and LLM-judge verdicts vary run to run

Single free model

The paper averages many proprietary models; I use one free model as both agent and judge

Direction > absolute

Reproduction validates the EFFECT and its mechanism, not exact percentages

Mitigations the paper tested (all partial)

Model	**Lightweight safety post-training (DPO)** Safe Rate 59.5% → 62.75% — doesn't fully restore
Memory	**Prompt: “memories are references, not rules”** ASR 20.6% → 13.1%; Refusal 54% → 67%
Tool	**Static analysis + judge re-validation on reuse** External-ingestion refusal 7% → 69% with a safety prompt
Workflow	**Safety instruction added to the Ensemble node** ASR 83.1% → 77.5% — a reactive “patch”

Common thread: prompt-level fixes reduce risk but never fully recover safety — a robust solution is still open.

Key takeaways

Misevolution is real and pervasive

Self-improvement can erode safety across model, memory, tool, and workflow — even on top-tier LLMs.

It's a NEW kind of risk

Emergent over time, self-generated, hard to control with training data, and spread across many components.

I reproduced 3 of 4 pathways with free models

Memory 76.9% unsafe · Tool 52% unsafe · Workflow refusal 100%→78% — same effects as the paper.

The 4th needs a bigger GPU

Model misevolution requires local 7B–70B checkpoints; wired and ready for ≥16 GB hardware.

Current mitigations are only partial

Safer self-evolving agents need new safety frameworks — an open research problem.

Thank you

Paper: “Your Agent May Misevolve: Emergent Risks in Self-Evolving LLM Agents”, ICLR 2026

Reproduction: minimax-m3:free · Memory + Tool + Workflow pathways · results in RESULTS/FINDINGS.md

Code, patches & data: RESULTS/ and CHANGES_FREE_MODELS.md